

cence to the 30s, tracking the ebbs and flows of womanhood along the way. No judgement is cast as she has strange (read immoral) dreams and fumbles in her relationships.

Varsha's clever character study sees her take Ramya through a journey which, when projected on to a hero, mostly comes across as a lionised, fun take on masculinity. But as the title illustrates, the filmmaker establishes how all-pervasive patriarchy means Ramya will be vilified and ascribed with tags like "crazy" and "troublemaker" for having familiar feelings and emotions.

This is best depicted in Ramya's college romance where she is shown to be head-over-heels in love with a Telugu man named Arjun (cinephiles will easily deduce the wink-wink here). Self-doubt creeps in as she resorts to desperate, demeaning ways to get his attention. "OK, I will be a good girl. I will eat," she tells him. It's with dialogues like this that Varsha subtly captures the moral standards and emotional manipulation women endure.

Anjali Sivaraman has a striking presence, but she's not always able to tap into the complexities of the enigmatic Ramya, especially when she is older and newly single. *Bad Girl* is most moving when it's exploring the delicate and, in this case, volatile, mother-daughter bond. More than a coming-of-age tale, the film excels in capturing how two women adjust their dreams and lives as they navigate the mores imposed on them. ■

—Suhani Singh



▲ **OCTOBER 10**

SEARCH: THE NAINA MURDER CASE

Konkona Sensharma, winner of two National Awards, and with nothing to prove, had never played a tough cop in formals, stealthily walking into a corner, gun in hand. "She's our best," an associate announces about her character in the trailer. She's investigating a murder mystery involving a teenager, Naina, on this JioHotstar series directed by Rohan Sippy (*Bluffmaster*).



▲ **OCTOBER 10**

Lord Curzon Ki Haveli

A dinner party where one guest reveals, "there's a dead body in the trunk". That's a juicy premise which promises a throwback to Agatha Christie mysteries and Alfred Hitchcock thrillers of yore, particularly 1948's *Rope*. Talented actor Anshuman Jha turns director with this psychological thriller that boasts an acclaimed ensemble cast: Rasika Dugal, Arjun Mathur, Tanmay Dhanania, Paresh Pahuja.

◀ **OCTOBER 21**

THAMMA

The latest instalment in Maddock Films' monstrously profitable horror-comedy universe, *Thamma* tackles vampires. The previous films in this world include the *Stree* franchise and *Munjya*. The plot follows a present-day historian obsessed with vampirism in Indian folklore.

Cast: Ayushmann Khurrana, Rashmika Mandanna, Nawazuddin Siddiqui and Paresh Rawal



◀ **OCTOBER 17**

BISON

Acclaimed Tamil anti-caste filmmaker Mari Selvaraj is back. Starring Dhruv Vikram and Anupama Parameswaran, *Bison* is loosely based on the life of kabaddi player Manathi Ganesan. Selvaraj's first, *Pariyerum Perumal* (2018), was recently remade in Hindi as *Dhadak 2*.

—Compiled by Devarsi Ghosh